movement. In terms of its sources of support, India was stuck with the Soviet presence in Afghanistan, which was a no-win situation in all circumstances. As the USSR came under pressure at the same time as India, the two countries became bound to each other even closer. For India, what started as an effective exploitation of a global contradiction ended as an impasse of some consequence.

The 1980s perhaps offers even more insights than the 1960s, mainly as it saw transformational events. Three of them merit special attention: Afghanistan as a reading of global politics, Sri Lanka as the challenge of boots on the ground, and China as the benefit of playing contradictions. The most consequential, without doubt, was the Afghan jihad. Looking back, it appears that India misjudged the extent to which Western countries would utilize it to damage the USSR. More relevant, the intensity of their support created the window for Pakistan to go through with its nuclear programme. It could be argued that India had little choice in the matter even if it had read the situation better. But it did take a full generation to put behind us the consequences of these events. Today, some vicarious satisfaction can be derived from the fact that the first jihad has come back to haunt Western countries. But the strategic damage of this period is difficult to overstate. As for its catastrophic impact on the USSR, this was truly a black swan, one not foreseen even by the most experienced analysts of that era.

The second issue which has got less attention than it deserves was the peacekeeping intervention in Sri Lanka. The US had gone through a similar experience in Lebanon just a few years earlier. The question relates to the deployment of boots on the ground abroad. Fingers can be pointed in many directions, including limited comprehension of local attitudes and interests, lack of preparation, paucity of intelligence and counter-insurgency tactics. Interestingly, in the same period, Indian forces displayed great grit and determination in fighting off secessionist forces in Punjab and Jammu and Kashmir. As these memories recede and calls for deployment abroad recur from time to time, it is imperative that India carefully weighs the compulsions with its costs.

China’s rise is especially instructive for India. It was driving diplomatically in the late 1970s efforts to forge a united front against the USSR. This is in